

WF

CHRISTMAS 2026 EDITION

WILEY FOX TRAVEL
FAMILIES AND SOLO TRAVELLERS

THE WILEY FOX GUIDE TO

Chicago

For families & solo travellers

WILEY FOX RATING • MODERATE

3

OUT OF 5 • POLICE DATA JUN 2026 TO AUG 2026

CREATOR FEELING 4/5 • COMFORTABLE DOWNTOWN - QUIET AFTER DARK

20 Nov

CHRISTKINDLMARKET AND TREE LIGHTING 2026

The Daley Plaza market runs 20 November to 24 December; the city tree is lit in Millennium Park at 6pm the same Friday.

\$5

A 1-DAY CTA PASS

Unlimited L trains and buses for 24 hours. A 3-day pass is \$15 and a 7-day pass \$20 (CTA, Oct 2026). Tap a contactless card to ride.

130

CREATORS · 181 VIDEOS

Paraphrased and credited, cross-checked with police data.

Chicago is a big, flat grid on the shore of Lake Michigan. Visitors spend most of their time in a compact area: the Loop (the business district inside the elevated L tracks, with Millennium Park and the Art Institute), River North and the Magnificent Mile just across the river, Streeterville and Navy Pier by the lake, and the Museum Campus to the south. The L trains, buses and the lakefront make it easy to reach neighbourhoods like Lincoln Park, Wicker Park, Chinatown and Pilsen. Creators suggest three or four days.

At Christmas the city puts on a big show: the German-style Christkindlmarket on Daley Plaza (in its 30th year in 2026), a 60-foot tree and free skating in Millennium Park, a skating ribbon in Maggie Daley Park, the Magnificent Mile Lights Festival parade, ZooLights at the free Lincoln Park Zoo, Macy's Walnut Room and Christmas Around the World at the Museum of Science and Industry. Families get huge, hands-on museums for cold days.

For solo travellers downtown is easy, friendly and walkable, and creators - women included - mostly felt safe. Plan for the cold (wind off the lake makes freezing days feel far colder), early darkness (sunset about 4:20pm), a Loop that empties in the evening, late-night trains, and a sales tax that is never on the price tag.

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Chicago publishes street-level crime data, and the Wiley Fox map shows it hex by hex. Before you book, check your hotel's block - the difference between the Magnificent Mile and a quiet street a mile west can be large.

Fast facts

CURRENCY	US dollar (USD) - cards and phone pay work almost everywhere, but many Christkindlmarket food stalls have been cash only; tax is added at the till
LANGUAGE	English
TIME_ZONE	Central Time (UTC-6) - six hours behind the UK in December
PLUG	Type A and B, 120V - UK plugs need an adaptor; check chargers are dual voltage
EMERGENCY	911 police, fire and ambulance · 311 police non-emergency and city services (24 hours)
ENTRY	UK passport plus an approved ESTA before you fly - the official fee is \$40.27 on esta.cbp.dhs.gov ; other sites charge more (CBP, Oct 2026)
TIPPING	About 18-20% in restaurants is usual (staff earn a lower base wage); check the bill for service charges first
BEST_TIME	Late November to 23 December for the Christmas events (weekday mornings are calmest); May-June and September for the lakefront

THE FESTIVE SEASON

Christmas in Chicago

Chicago does Christmas on a big scale. The Christkindlmarket on Daley Plaza, modelled on Nuremberg's and in its 30th year in 2026, opens on 20 November - the same evening the city lights its Christmas tree in Millennium Park - and the Magnificent Mile Lights Festival parade follows the next day. Add free skating, ZooLights, the Walnut Room and Christmas Around the World, and there is plenty for families. The flip side is crowds: in 2025 the city capped numbers at the market and queues formed outside.

Christmas markets



Photo: Daniel X. O'Neill from USA · CC BY 2.0

Christkindlmarket Chicago (Daley Plaza)

THE LOOP • 20 NOV - 24 DEC 2026 • SUN-THU 11AM-8PM, FRI-SAT 11AM-9PM •
THANKSGIVING (26 NOV) AND 24 DEC 11AM-4PM • GREAT FOR KIDS



A German-style market of wooden huts under the skyscrapers since 1996, with 50+ vendors (many from Germany): glass ornaments (including Chicago Bean ones), nutcrackers, gingerbread, bratwurst, pretzels, the famous raclette sandwich (about \$17-18 in 2023-24) and Glühwein or hot chocolate in the collectable annual mug. Children get a free Kinder Club riddle passport, and there is a heated hall to warm up. A Krampus tent may frighten little ones.

Crowds: Very busy - queues of 20-40 people at food stalls and up to two hours for raclette at lunch. In 2025 the city capped the plaza at about 1,500 then 2,500 people, with queues outside. Weekday mornings are calmest. Creators found most food stalls cash only; ATMs are on site.

Via [A World Jo Traveled](#), [LeggLife](#), [NatashaVentures](#), [LukeGee Travels](#), [Through My Lens](#), [WGN News](#), [CBS Chicago](#), [Backttalk](#), [Eat Local](#), [Creatives En Route](#) | [Dev + Phil](#), [Fixology](#)

Free entry · mug \$10 empty, Glühwein about \$12 with mug (2023-25)

DETAILS



Christkindlmarket Wrigleyville & Winterland

GALLAGHER WAY, WRIGLEY FIELD · 20 NOV - 31 DEC 2026 · MON-THU 3-9PM, FRI-SAT 11AM-9PM, SUN 11AM-7PM · 24 DEC 11AM-4PM · CLOSED 25 DEC · GREAT FOR KIDS

Back in 2026 after two years away. Creators preferred it to downtown for families: shorter queues, a carousel, skating, s'mores, a kids' train and a heated beer hall, with entry to the ballpark area about \$5-10 in 2022-23.

Crowds: Less crowded than downtown; a younger crowd in the evenings.

Via [Backttalk](#), [Eat Local](#), [Michael In The City](#)

Check 2026 prices

DETAILS

Millennium Park tree lighting & holiday market

MILLENNIUM PARK · FRI 20 NOV 2026, LIGHTING AT 6PM · MARKET 20-22 NOV ONLY · TREE UP TO 10 JAN 2027 · GREAT FOR KIDS

The 113th city tree lighting, with music from 5pm and Santa in 2025; a free weekend market of about 40 vendors runs beside it. The tree then stands by the Bean all season.

Crowds: Packed on lighting night. After the 2025 lighting, a large teen gathering nearby turned violent - with children, leave as the event ends.

Via [CBS Chicago](#), [LukeGee Travels](#), [Tours by Foot - Chicago](#)

Free

DETAILS

Christkindlmarket Aurora

RIVEREDGE PARK, AURORA (ABOUT 40 MILES WEST) • 20 NOV - 24 DEC 2026 • THU-SUN
(HOURS VARY) • GREAT FOR KIDS



A smaller sister market in the suburbs, with its own collectable mug. Only worth it if you have a car or are staying west.

Crowds: Calmer than downtown.

Via [The Journey Begins](#), [Fixology](#), [Escapades With Ernie](#)

Free entry

DETAILS

Lights, rinks and festive sights



ZooLights, Lincoln Park Zoo

LINCOLN PARK • 20 NOV 2026 - 3 JAN 2027 • 4:30-9PM • CLOSED 26 NOV, 1, 8, 15, 24 AND 25 DEC • GREAT FOR KIDS

Lights across the free zoo, with skyline views, hot chocolate and s'mores, and Santa photos. Everyone needs a ticket, including babies; free Mondays (booking needed) on 23 and 30 Nov and 7 and 14 Dec.

Crowds: Busy on weekends. Toilets are hard to find, and rideshares near impossible at rush hour - take the 151 bus or Brown Line.

Via [LukeGee Travels](#), [Caira Button](#), [Backttalk](#), [Allison Anderson](#)

\$7-12 in advance • \$20 on the day (2026)

DETAILS

Magnificent Mile Lights Festival

MICHIGAN AVENUE • SAT 21 NOV 2026 • PARADE 5:30PM FROM OAK STREET, HEADING SOUTH • GREAT FOR KIDS



The 35th parade of floats, characters and Santa, lighting the trees along Michigan Avenue block by block. The lights then stay up all season.

Crowds: Several blocks get dangerously packed - one creator had to turn back in 2025. Arrive early and agree a meeting point.

Via [Samuel Ciochon - Your Chicago Lifestyle](#), [Tours by Foot - Chicago](#), [Annika](#)

Free

DETAILS



Photo: Flickr user laffy4k · [CC BY 2.0](#)

McCormick Tribune Ice Rink

MILLENNIUM PARK • 20 NOV 2026 - FEB 2027 • DAILY 11AM-10:30PM • GREAT FOR KIDS

Skate under the Bean and the city tree. The city says admission is free; creators needed an online time slot.

Crowds: Slots sell out over the holidays - one creator only got 8am.

Via [Tours by Foot - Chicago](#), [A World Jo Traveled](#), [Sydnei Alicia](#), [Caira Button](#)

Free · skate hire extra

DETAILS

Maggie Daley Park Skating Ribbon

THE LOOP • 13 NOV 2026 - 7 MAR 2027 • TWO-HOUR SESSIONS • 24 AND 25 DEC MORNINGS ONLY • GREAT FOR KIDS



A quarter-mile ribbon of ice winding uphill and down through the trees with skyline views. Skates run big, so size down.

Crowds: Much quieter than the Millennium Park rink.

Via [Through My Lens](#), [CURIO](#), [Luis Gusto](#), [Chad and Claire](#)

Ticket for every session · skate hire \$17-23

DETAILS



Macy's on State Street & the Walnut Room

THE LOOP · GREAT TREE 7 NOV - 10 JAN · GREAT FOR KIDS

The old Marshall Field's store: themed windows, Frango mints and the Walnut Room's giant tree, where families eat chicken pot pie under the branches. Book on OpenTable early - one creator found it sold out a month ahead - but you can glimpse the tree from outside the restaurant.

Crowds: Busy at weekends.

Via [Through My Lens](#), [CBS Chicago](#), [Luis Gusto](#), [Backttalk](#), [Tours by Foot - Chicago](#)

Free to look

DETAILS



Christmas Around the World, MSI

HYDE PARK · FROM 7 NOV 2026 · GREAT FOR KIDS

A tradition since 1942: a four-storey Grand Tree and around 50 trees decorated by Chicago's communities, included with museum entry.

Crowds: Very busy the week before Christmas - go early.

Via [Through My Lens](#), [CBS Chicago](#)

Museum admission

DETAILS

Winter WonderFest, Navy Pier

STREETERVILLE • 27 NOV 2026 - 3 JAN 2027 • CLOSED 25 DEC • GREAT FOR KIDS

An indoor winter fair with rides, slides and skating, out of the cold.

Crowds: Busiest at weekends.

Via [A World Jo Traveled](#)

\$27 online · \$32 at the door · under 3 free (2026)

DETAILS

Lightscape, Chicago Botanic Garden

GLENCOE (ABOUT 25 MILES NORTH) • FROM 13 NOV • 4:30PM ONWARDS (CHECK 2026 DATES) • GREAT FOR KIDS

An illuminated evening trail with music, snacks and hot drinks. Best by car or Metra.

Crowds: Timed entry.

Via [Tours by Foot - Chicago](#), [Travel The Top](#)

Varies by date

DETAILS

The CTA Holiday Train

CHANGES LINE DAILY • DECEMBER • GREAT FOR KIDS

A train covered in lights with Santa in an open flatcar sleigh, running in normal service on a different line each day - check the CTA website.

Crowds: Can be packed - on 18 December 2024 riders at Washington were told to wait for the next one.

Via [Caira Button](#), [Through My Lens](#), [This Gemini](#)

Normal fare

Staying safe in the Christmas crowds

Crowds and timing

The Christkindlmarket is packed on Friday and Saturday evenings and calm on weekday mornings. The tree lighting (Fri 20 Nov) and the Lights Festival parade (Sat 21 Nov) fill whole blocks - arrive early, agree a meeting point and leave before the very end.

Via [A World Jo Traveled](#), [Eat Local](#), [Annika](#), [Backttalk](#)

Teen gatherings after big events

After the 2025 tree lighting, a large unsupervised teen gathering near State Street ended in shootings. Millennium Park now requires under-18s to be with an adult aged 21+ after 6pm Friday to Sunday, with bag checks at the Michigan Avenue gates. With children, enjoy the early evening and head back to your hotel as crowds of teenagers build. 2026 security plans had not been published by early October.

Via [TheDC Shorts](#), [LukeGee Travels](#)

Pickpockets and card skimming

The Better Business Bureau warns of 'bump and skim' card thieves in holiday crowds. Keep wallets in front pockets, bags zipped and phones in hand, and never let a stranger tap your phone or card for a 'donation'.

Via [CBS Chicago](#), [Wolters World](#)

Cash, mugs and prices

Creators found most market food stalls cash only, with ATM queues. Expect \$10-12 for food and drinks and \$10 for the annual mug (2023-25); \$20 bought just a coffee, a bratwurst and a pretzel in 2025.

Via [LeggLife](#), [LukeGee Travels](#), [A World Jo Traveled](#), [Creatives En Route](#) | [Dev + Phil](#)

Cold and dark

Sunset is about 4:20pm in December, and creators saw anything from 50°F with a -10°F wind chill to -13°C and snow. Most of the market is outdoors and standing - layers, hat, gloves, warm boots and hand warmers.

Via [LukeGee Travels](#), [Annika](#), [Arbaaz Vlogs](#), [Jiya Bhatia](#)

Have a lost-child plan

Before you go in, agree a meeting point everyone can find - the Picasso sculpture on Daley Plaza works for the market, the Bean for Millennium Park. A Wiley Fox QR wristband on each child means anyone who finds them can reach you straight away.

Wiley Fox data

New Year's Eve

Navy Pier fireworks over the lake are the classic New Year's Eve view, but 2026 details were not published by early October. Expect big crowds downtown and plan your route back.

Via [Lost in the Pond](#), [Go Places with Tati & Brennan](#)

In 2026 the Christkindlmarket and the city tree both start on Friday 20 November, and the Lights Festival parade is on Saturday 21 November. The Daley Plaza market closes at 4pm on 24 December; Wrigleyville runs to 31 December (closed on Christmas Day). ZooLights is closed on 24 and 25 December, and Navy Pier's WonderFest on the 25th. Thanksgiving is Thursday 26 November - expect closures and busy travel that weekend. Book skating, the Walnut Room and hotels early.

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Clip a Wiley Fox QR wristband on each child. If you get separated in the Christkindlmarket queue or at the tree, anyone who scans it can contact you straight away - no app needed on their side.

WHAT THE DATA AND THE CREATORS SAY

*How it feels, and what the numbers show**The data*

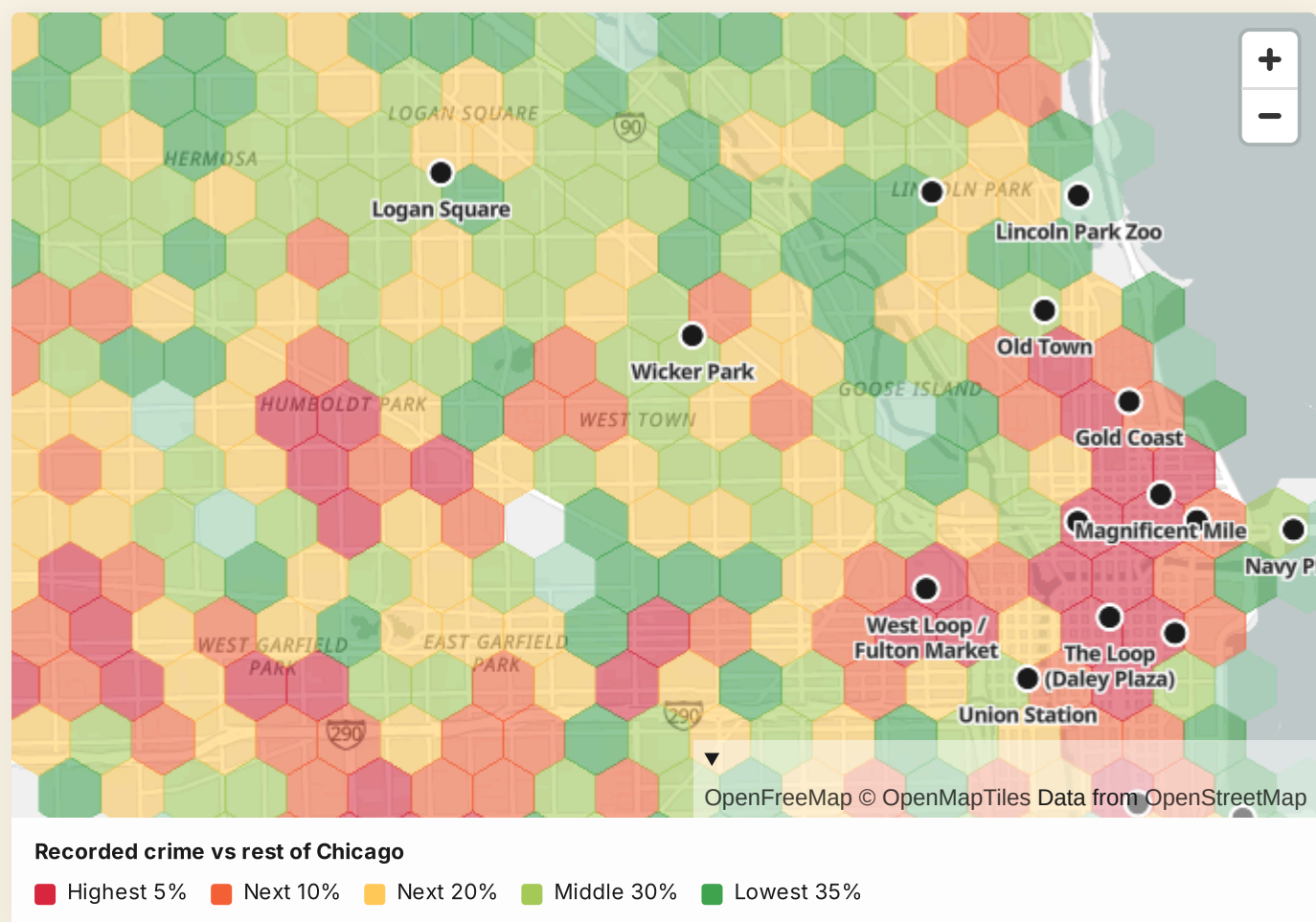
Chicago's reputation comes from gun violence, and that violence is real - 416 homicides in 2025 - but it is heavily concentrated in residential neighbourhoods on the South and West Sides, miles from where visitors stay. It is also falling fast: homicides fell 29% in 2025 to the lowest level since 1965, shooting victims fell 34% and robbery 36% (Chicago Police). In 2026 so far, recorded crime is down a further 9% in the downtown Central district and 7% in the Near North district that covers the Magnificent Mile. Downtown, the main risks for visitors are theft, pickpocketing and street scams, which cluster where the crowds are. Two things to plan for at Christmas: the Loop empties after office hours, and large unsupervised teen gatherings after big evening events have turned violent - on the night of the 2025 tree lighting, seven teenagers were shot near State Street and a 14-year-old was killed a few blocks away. This rating is for the city as a whole; check the area figures below for where you stay.

The creators

Most creators found downtown Chicago clean, walkable and safer than its reputation; several compared it favourably with New York, and solo women (LifeWithDayy, NK Medani, Izzy Bisges) felt comfortable by day and on the L. Locals keep repeating the same advice: the Loop is a ghost town after about 6-7pm, avoid empty train carriages late at night (the bus is safer because the driver can see you), and ignore anyone on the street asking for money for a ticket or a 'donation'. Pickpockets work Michigan Avenue, Navy Pier and L platforms. Creators who explored the South Side by day (CityNerd, Luis Gusto, Peter Santenello) found it calmer than the headlines, but advise staying alert and knowing where you are.

The Wiley Fox crime map of Chicago

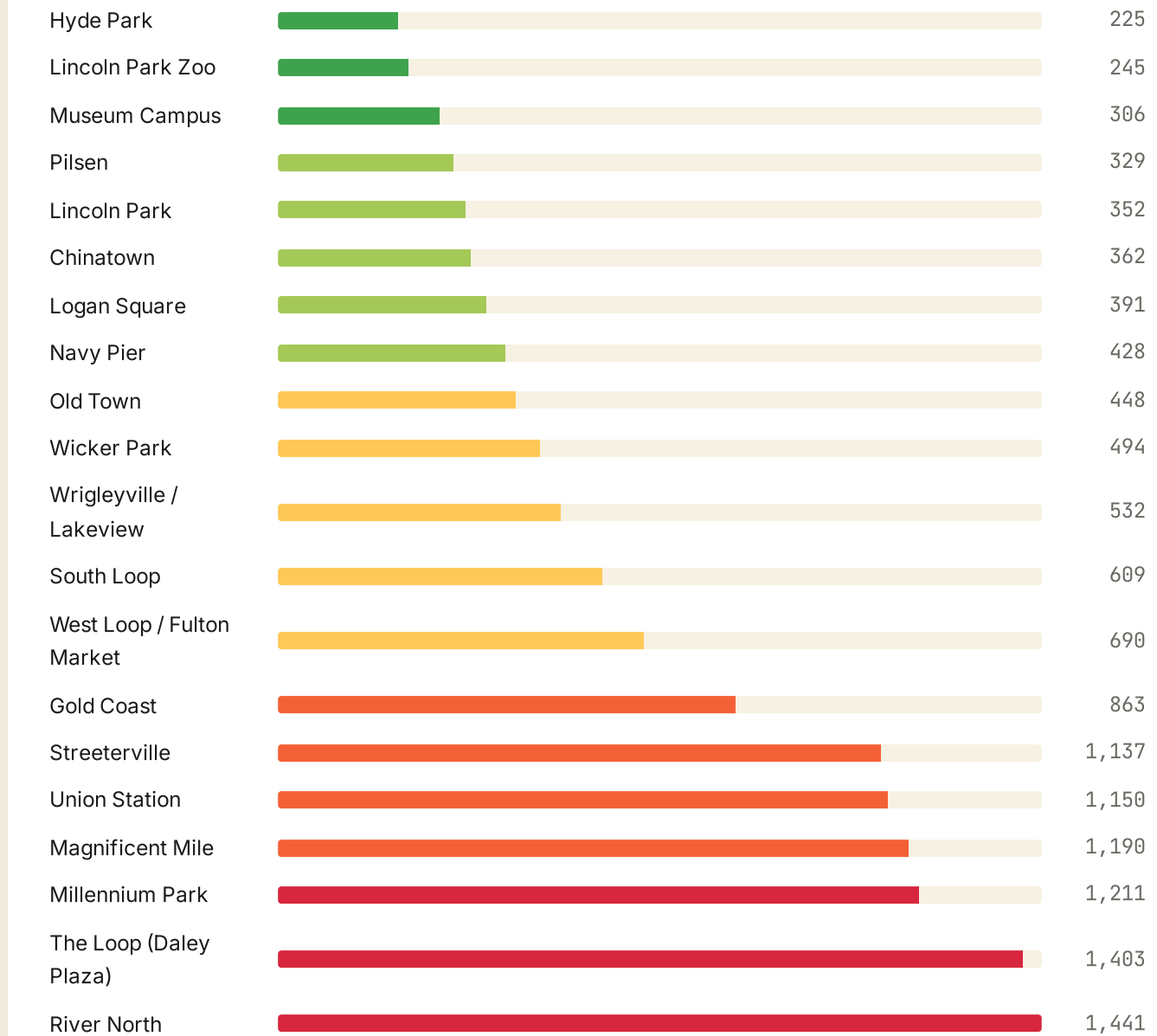
Every recorded crime in Aug 2026 from Chicago Police Department, Crimes data (City of Chicago Data Portal), weighted by seriousness the same way as the Wiley Fox app and grouped into 350-metre hexagons. Colours compare each hexagon with the rest of Chicago: red marks the busiest 5% of the city. Blank areas had no recorded crime. Busy tourist districts show up red partly because so many people pass through them. For a street-level score, open the Wiley Fox map.



20,688 crimes · Chicago Police Department, Crimes data (City of Chicago Data Portal) · [Check any street live on the Wiley Fox map](#)

Recorded crime by area

Area figures are the monthly average of crimes recorded by Chicago Police from June to August 2026 within about one mile of each area centre (City of Chicago Data Portal, the latest three complete months). Locations are published to block level. Summer months are busier than December, and busy downtown areas record more crime partly because so many people pass through them - River North, the Loop, Millennium Park and the Magnificent Mile circles overlap, so read them as one zone. Chicago counts incidents differently from New York, so do not compare these numbers with our New York guide. Citywide trends come from the Chicago Police 2025 year-end review and the Data Portal (January to 27 September 2026 against the same period in 2025).



■ Lowest
 ■ Lower
 ■ Moderate
 ■ High
 ■ Highest

How Chicago compares with the rest of the US

Offences per 100,000 residents in 2025, as reported to the FBI. Chicago is about 1.3 times the US average for violent crime and 1.9 times for property crime. Big cities always sit above the national average: millions of commuters and visitors are counted as victims but not as residents, and crime is concentrated in some neighbourhoods rather than spread evenly.

	VIOLENT CRIME	PROPERTY CRIME
Chicago police	420	2,956

	VIOLENT CRIME	PROPERTY CRIME
New York City police	660	2,300
Illinois	258	1,556
US average	329	1,552

per 100,000 residents, 2025

Violent crime is murder, rape, robbery and aggravated assault. Property crime is burglary, theft and vehicle theft. For the street you are on, use the area figures above or the Wiley Fox map. Chicago's homicide rate - about 15 per 100,000 residents in 2025 (Chicago Police) - is much higher than this overall violent-crime figure suggests, and is concentrated in a small number of South and West Side neighbourhoods. Source: [FBI Crime Data Explorer, agency summary data \(2024-2025\)](#)

Areas to take extra care

None of these are no-go areas. Know the pattern, and plan your timing and your route home.

● The Loop after dark and after big events

TAKE MOST CARE: EVENINGS, ESPECIALLY AFTER THE TREE LIGHTING AND OTHER BIG EVENTS

The Loop is a business district that empties after 6-7pm, so stick to lit, busy streets. On 21 November 2025, after the Millennium Park tree lighting, a large 'teen takeover' gathering near State Street ended with seven teenagers shot near the Chicago Theatre and a 14-year-old killed on Dearborn Street. Millennium Park now requires under-18s to be with an adult aged 21+ after 6pm, Friday to Sunday, with bag checks at the Michigan Avenue gates. With children, enjoy the early evening and head back as crowds of teenagers build.

1,403 crimes a month nearby · top: theft, violence, criminal damage

Via [Wolters World](#), [CURIO](#), [TheDC Shorts](#), [Camden David](#)

● Magnificent Mile, Streeterville and Navy Pier

TAKE MOST CARE: BUSY AFTERNOONS AND EVENINGS

Pickpockets work the crowds around Michigan Avenue, street performers, Navy Pier and L platforms. A shell game runs off the Mile in Streeterville, and the 'tap-to-pay donation' scam has been reported on East Ohio Street (June 2026). Keep bags zipped and wallets in front pockets, and never hand your phone or card to a stranger.

1,190 crimes a month nearby · top: theft, violence, criminal damage

Via [Wolters World](#), [Tours by Foot - Chicago](#), [CBS Chicago](#), [NBC Chicago](#)

- **L trains late at night**

TAKE MOST CARE: LATE EVENING AND NIGHT

The CTA says crime on trains fell sharply in 2026 after a security surge, but police data showed serious assaults on the system at a 24-year high in 2025, and creators still describe smoking, drug use and the odd attack on Red and Blue Line trains. At night, pick a busy carriage near the driver (the first car), avoid empty ones, or take the bus, where the driver can see you.

Via [Tours by Foot - Chicago](#), [Chicago Like A Local](#), [Chism Prism](#), [adulting with angela](#), [ABC 7 Chicago](#)

- **Union Station and transport hubs**

TAKE MOST CARE: ANY TIME

Wolters World says that on nearly every visit someone has approached with a story about needing money for a train ticket to Milwaukee or a bus. Say no and keep walking, or offer to go to the ticket office with them.

1,150 crimes a month nearby · top: theft, violence, criminal damage

Via [Wolters World](#)

- **Bridges into the West Loop at night**

TAKE MOST CARE: LATE NIGHT

The West Loop is busy and well used, but the walk over the river bridges from the Loop or River North can be isolated after dark. Take a taxi or rideshare when alone. In 2025 the Fulton Market business association warned of fake parking attendants in hi-vis vests charging drivers \$20.

690 crimes a month nearby · top: theft, violence, criminal damage

Via [Tours by Foot - Chicago](#), [CBS Chicago](#)

- **Unfamiliar South and West Side neighbourhoods**

TAKE MOST CARE: AFTER DARK

Most of Chicago's violence happens in residential neighbourhoods on the South and West Sides, well away from the visitor areas. Places visitors go - Hyde Park and the Museum of Science and Industry, Chinatown, Pilsen, Bridgeport - are fine by day, and creators who explored further found them calmer than the headlines. Don't wander blocks you don't know after dark, and keep nothing on show in a parked car.

Via [Luis Gusto](#), [CityNerd](#), [Peter Santenello](#), [VIP Trip Deals](#), [Wolters World](#)

- **Winter streets and the lakefront**

TAKE MOST CARE: DECEMBER TO MARCH

Snow and ice can slide off tall buildings downtown - don't stand underneath for photos. Wind off the lake makes it feel far colder than the thermometer says, and ice on the lake and harbours is never safe. Drivers are aggressive at crossings, and fast e-bikes use the lakefront path.

Via [Wolters World](#), [LukeGee Travels](#), [Luis Gusto](#), [CBS Chicago](#)

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The Loop goes quiet after dark. Save your hotel on Wiley Fox, stick to lit, busy streets or take the bus, and keep SOS one tap away.

Scams and tricks creators keep seeing

The 'tap-to-pay donation'

Strangers ask for a small donation, often for a funeral, refuse cash and ask to tap your phone or card - then charge thousands. Reported in Streeterville, the West Loop, Lincoln Park, Wicker Park and Lakeview in 2025-26; banks can refuse refunds because you authorised the payment. The Better Business Bureau says refusing cash is a red flag.

Via [CBS Chicago](#), [NBC Chicago](#)

Shell games and street pitches

Card and ball-and-cup games off the Magnificent Mile are rigged, and pickpockets work the crowd that gathers to watch. Downtown you may also be pushed to sign up for dubious subscriptions - keep walking.

Via [Wolters World](#), [CBS Chicago](#), [Chism Prism](#)

Money for a train ticket

Sob stories at Union Station and other hubs about needing money for a ticket home. Offer to buy the ticket at the counter with them, or say no.

Via [Wolters World](#)

Taxis

Some drivers claim the card machine is broken and ask for cash - check before you get in. After games at the United Center, unlicensed cabs and flat-rate fares (\$40-45 against about \$20 on the meter) were reported. Genuine cabs show a roof number that matches the plate; the Curb and Arro apps book licensed taxis.

Via [Wolters World](#), [ABC 7 Chicago](#)

Fake parking attendants

People in hi-vis vests have waved drivers into private lots in Fulton Market and around Sox games, charging \$20-40. Park only in official garages, or use the SpotHero app.

Via [CBS Chicago](#)

Bills, fees and upsells

The 10.25% sales tax is never on the price tag, restaurants add a 0.5% tax, and some add a service fee or about 3% surcharge - check before tipping. Deep-dish pizzerias push starters you won't need: even a small pizza is very filling.

Via [Travel Tips Group](#), [Brad Ball Travels](#), [Rithmic ASMR](#), [Wolters World](#)

NEIGHBOURHOODS

Where to stay

Pick an area first, then a hotel. Every area card shows the latest recorded crime within about a mile, so you can compare busy against calm.



Photo: Spatms · CC BY-SA 4.0

River North

HIGHEST RECORDED CRIME

FIRST-TIMERS • FAMILIES • NIGHTLIFE

The most recommended base: just north of the river, walkable to the Loop, the Magnificent Mile and the Riverwalk, with big hotels, deep-dish pizza and bars. Pricey and busy near Michigan Avenue, and the area records some of the city's highest theft counts because of the crowds - keep phones close. The Red Line stops at Grand and Chicago.

1,441 crimes a month nearby • 52% theft • 22% violence or robbery

Via [Travel Tips Group](#), [Samuel Ciochon - Your Chicago Lifestyle](#), [Camden David](#), [Caira Button](#), [MissTourist](#), [trovexgo](#)

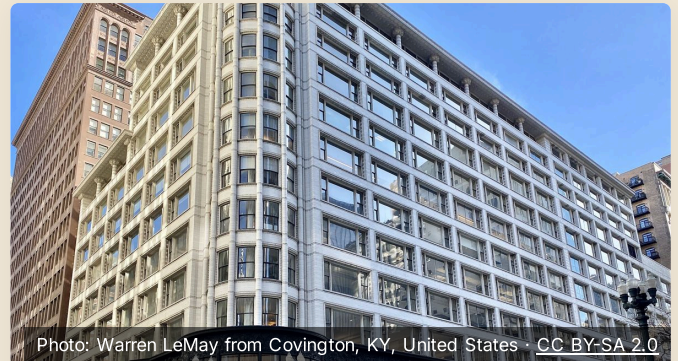


Photo: Warren LeMay from Covington, KY, United States · CC BY-SA 2.0

The Loop

HIGHEST RECORDED CRIME

CHRISTMAS MARKETS • MUSEUMS • SHORT STAYS

About 80% of the main sights are here - the Christkindlmarket, Millennium Park, the Art Institute - and every L line except the Yellow stops here. Hotels are fewer and pricier, and creators warn it empties after 6-7pm and at weekends, so it can feel deserted at night. Through My Lens found a Cambria hotel a block from the market for under \$100 a night in early December 2023.

1,403 crimes a month nearby • 49% theft • 22% violence or robbery

Via [Travel Tips Group](#), [Camden David](#), [Wolters World](#), [MissTourist](#), [Through My Lens](#)

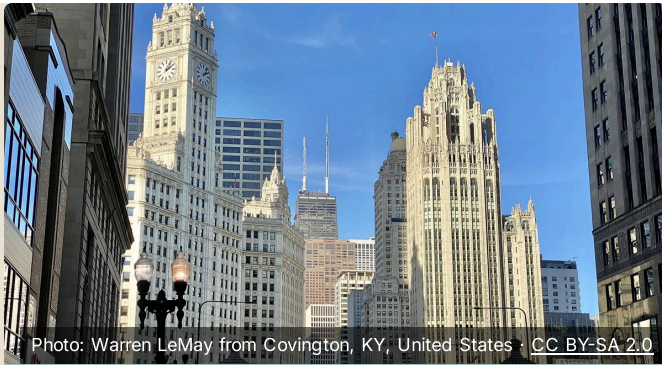


Photo: Warren LeMay from Covington, KY, United States · CC BY-SA 2.0

Magnificent Mile & Streeterville

HIGH RECORDED CRIME

SHOPPING · FAMILIES · HOTEL CHOICE

Michigan Avenue north of the river, with the most hotel choice, the Christmas lights, Water Tower Place and Navy Pier ten minutes east. Hotels here are often cheaper than the Loop. Camden David says Streeterville is far from the L and not special for a first visit, and the street scams creators warn about cluster around Michigan Avenue.

1,190 crimes a month nearby · 53% theft · 23% violence or robbery

Via [Travel Tips Group](#), [MissTourist](#), [TRIP XTREME](#), [Camden David](#), [Ashlynn Eaton](#)

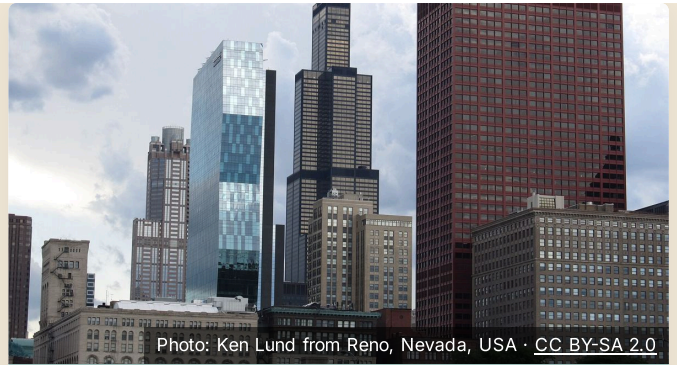


Photo: Ken Lund from Reno, Nevada, USA · CC BY-SA 2.0

South Loop

MODERATE RECORDED CRIME

FAMILIES · BUDGET · MUSEUMS

South of the Loop beside Grant Park and the Museum Campus (Field Museum, Shedd Aquarium, Adler Planetarium). Hotels on South Michigan Avenue can be cheaper, Printers Row has good food, and the HI Chicago hostel is here. Further from the Magnificent Mile and quieter at night.

609 crimes a month nearby · 38% theft · 29% violence or robbery

Via [MissTourist](#), [Roaming Routes](#), [Caira Button](#), [Travel Tips Group](#)



Photo: Krzysztof Ziarnik, Kenraiz · CC BY-SA 4.0

Lincoln Park & Old Town

LOWER RECORDED CRIME

FAMILIES · QUIET NIGHTS · ZOO

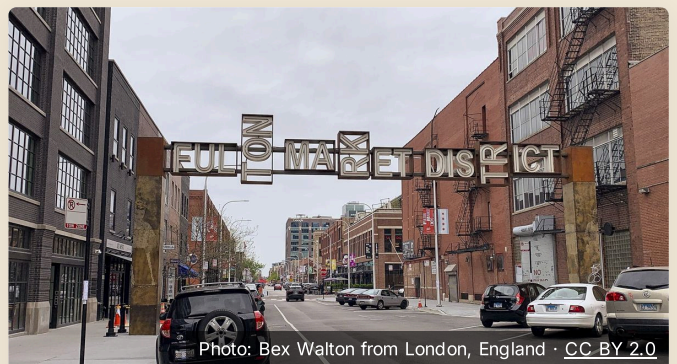


Photo: Bex Walton from London, England · CC BY 2.0

West Loop & Fulton Market

MODERATE RECORDED CRIME

Leafy, residential and described by every creator as safe, with the free zoo, ZooLights, the conservatory and the lakefront on the doorstep; Old Town has Second City comedy. A little far from the downtown action - 15-20 minutes on the Brown or Red Line or bus 151.

352 crimes a month nearby · 47% theft · 19% violence or robbery

Via [Tours by Foot - Chicago](#), [Chism Prism](#), [MissTourist](#), [Camden David](#), [Samuel Ciochon](#) - [Your Chicago Lifestyle](#)

FOOD · [SOLO TRAVELLERS](#) · [COUPLES](#)

Chicago's restaurant row on Randolph Street and Fulton Market, with design hotels like the Hoxton. Safe and busy by day, but the bridge walks from the Loop can feel isolated at night - Tours by Foot suggests a taxi when alone. The Pink and Green Lines serve it.

690 crimes a month nearby · 38% theft · 17% violence or robbery

Via [Camden David](#), [Tours by Foot - Chicago](#), [Zander Springer](#), [Caira Button](#), [MissTourist](#)

Hotels we'd start with

Wiley Fox may earn a small commission if you book through these links. Your price stays the same.

MAGNIFICENT MILE · LUXURY

The Peninsula Chicago

Five-star on the Mile with a rooftop spa and pool and afternoon tea.

\$\$\$\$ PRICE BAND

SEE PRICES

Via [Tours In Minutes](#)

STREETERVILLE · FAMILIES

Loews Chicago Hotel

A 75-foot pool, free loans of games and pool toys, free cribs, and cookies and cocoa on arrival for families (2022).

\$\$\$ PRICE BAND

SEE PRICES

Via [Details in Luxury](#)

STREETERVILLE · FAMILIES ON A BUDGET

DoubleTree by Hilton Magnificent Mile

Typically \$150-200 a night (2026), near Navy Pier, with a welcome cookie and a pool.

\$\$ PRICE BAND

SEE PRICES

Via [Best Hotels and Resorts](#)

RIVER NORTH · GOOD VALUE, CENTRAL

Royal Sonesta Chicago River North

A minute from the Red Line, with an indoor pool; about \$170 a night (2024).

\$\$ PRICE BAND

SEE PRICES

Via [Hotel tips](#)

THE LOOP • SOLO TRAVELLERS

citizenM Chicago Downtown

Compact, iPad-controlled rooms between the Riverwalk and Millennium Park, good value for one or two - not for families (2025).

\$\$ PRICE BAND

SEE PRICES

Via [Lia Lavon](#)

LAKEVIEW / LINCOLN PARK • QUIET & BUDGET

Hotel Versey

Quiet, artistic hotel near the zoo and the lake, about \$120-170 a night (2026).

\$\$ PRICE BAND

SEE PRICES

Via [Best Hotels and Resorts](#)

Search all Chicago hotels

Compare live prices, then check the street on the Wiley Fox map before you book.

SEARCH BOOKING.COM

WF

Clip a Wiley Fox QR wristband on each child. If you get separated in the Christkindlmarket queue or at the tree, anyone who scans it can contact you straight away - no app needed on their side.

WHAT CREATORS RATE

Twelve things worth your time

Ranked by how often creators recommend them. Most are in or near the Loop; in December do the outdoor sights by day (sunset is about 4:20pm) and save the lights for the evening. The famous architecture river cruise runs March to November only.

01



Photo: Behnazkhazai · CC BY-SA 3.0

Millennium Park & Cloud Gate

THE LOOP • GREAT FOR KIDS

The Bean, the Crown Fountain and, from 20 November 2026, the city Christmas tree and a free ice rink. Go at 8-9am for the Bean without the crowds - a December weekend afternoon drew about a thousand people. Under-18s need an adult 21+ after 6pm Friday to Sunday.

Via [Epic Family Escapes](#), [Luis Gusto](#), [Project Gaia](#), [CURIO](#), [Town Travel Tips](#), [Annika](#), [Triply](#)

Free

DETAILS

02

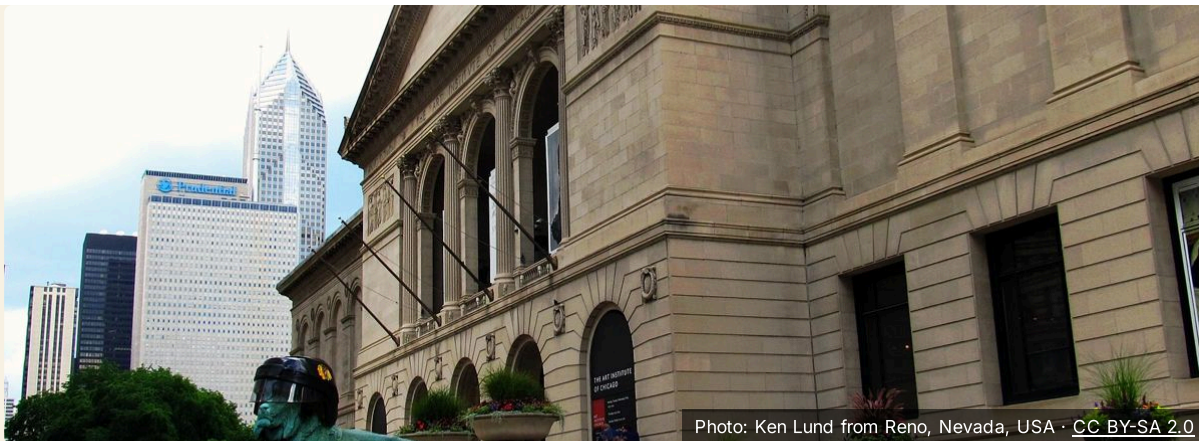


Photo: Ken Lund from Reno, Nevada, USA · [CC BY-SA 2.0](#)

Art Institute of Chicago

THE LOOP • GREAT FOR KIDS

A world-class museum: American Gothic, the Impressionists and the Thorne miniature rooms (decorated at Christmas), with wreaths on the lions outside. Allow at least half a day. Closed on Tuesdays; buy online.

Via [Wolters World](#), [ashley alondra](#), [Ashlynn Eaton](#), [Izzy Bisges](#), [Lia Lavon](#), [CBS Chicago](#)

\$32 adult · children free (2026)

DETAILS

03

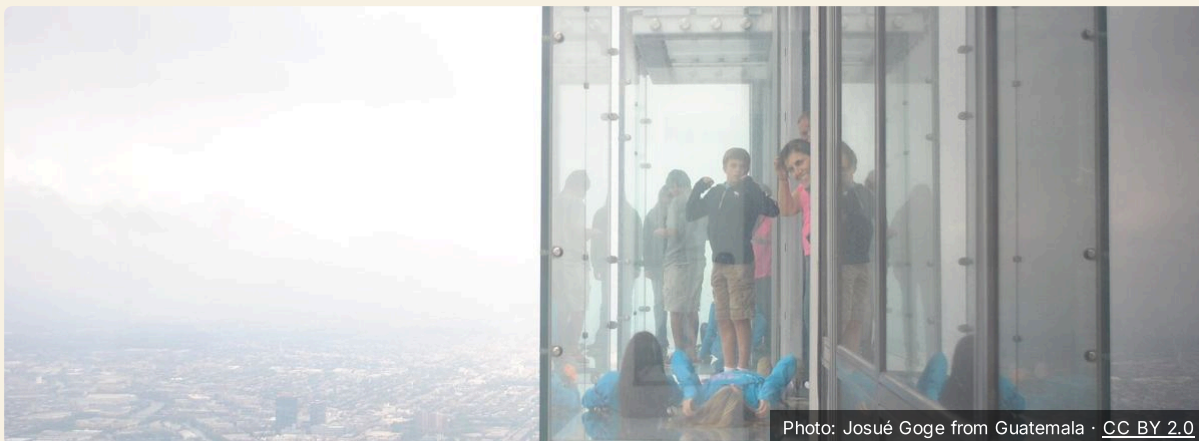


Photo: Josué Goge from Guatemala · [CC BY 2.0](#)

Willis Tower Skydeck

THE LOOP • GREAT FOR KIDS

103 floors up, with the Ledge glass boxes 1,353 feet above the street - about a minute each. Pricey, and pointless on a cloudy day, so book late or check the forecast. Open every day of the year; early weekday mornings are quietest.

Via [Outside with Dad](#), [CURIO](#), [Through My Lens](#), [Have Clothes](#), [Will Travel](#), [NK Medani](#), [Destinations2see](#), [Wolters World](#)

From \$32 · child 3-11 from \$24 (2026)

DETAILS

04



Field Museum

MUSEUM CAMPUS • GREAT FOR KIDS

Home of Sue, the most complete T. rex found, and the Tsavo lions; families spent most of a day here. Closed on Christmas Day.

Via [Outside with Dad](#), [Wolters World](#), [Daily Drop Pro](#), [Anna & Karl Travel](#), [Town Travel Tips](#)

\$30 adult (2026)

DETAILS

05



Photo: Knarfol at de.wikipedia · [Public domain](#)

Museum of Science and Industry

HYDE PARK · GREAT FOR KIDS

Huge and hands-on: a coal mine, a WWII U-boat, a tornado - and from 7 November 2026, Christmas Around the World, with a four-storey tree and dozens of trees decorated by Chicago's communities. Very busy the week before Christmas, so go early.

Via [Wolters World](#), [Means To Travel](#), [Through My Lens](#), [CBS Chicago](#), [United](#)

\$25.95 adult · child 3-11 \$14.95 (2026)

DETAILS

06



Photo: Krzysztof Ziarnek, Kenraiz · [CC BY-SA 4.0](#)

Lincoln Park Zoo & Conservatory

LINCOLN PARK · GREAT FOR KIDS

One of the few free zoos in the US, open every day, with indoor animal houses for cold days and the free Lincoln Park Conservatory next door (a big poinsettia show in December). In the evening it becomes ZooLights.

Via [Luis Gusto](#), [Travel Navigator](#), [Crosby Grace Travels](#), [Epic Family Escapes](#), [Caira Button](#), [Town Travel Tips](#)

Free

07



Photo: Diego Delso · CC BY-SA 3.0

Shedd Aquarium

MUSEUM CAMPUS · GREAT FOR KIDS

Beluga whales, a Polar Play Zone and the Wild Reef, next to the Field Museum. Prices for non-residents change by date, so check online.

Via [Epic Family Escapes](#), [Means To Travel](#), [Samuel Ciochon - Your Chicago Lifestyle](#)

Varies by date – check online

08



Photo: Daniel Schwen · CC BY-SA 4.0

360 Chicago

MAGNIFICENT MILE · GREAT FOR KIDS

The 94th-floor deck of the former John Hancock Center, with lake views and the TILT ride (extra). Curio suggests a drink in the Signature Lounge upstairs for similar views at a similar price.

Via [Way2go தமிழ்](#), [Destinations2see](#), [CURIO](#), [Have Clothes, Will Travel](#)

From \$30 · child 3-11 from \$20 (2026)

09



Photo: Moses8910 · CC BY-SA 4.0

Navy Pier & the Children's Museum

STREETERVILLE · GREAT FOR KIDS

Touristy and expensive, but children love the Centennial Wheel and the three-floor Chicago Children's Museum. In winter the indoor Winter WonderFest runs from 27 November 2026, with rides and skating. Watch your belongings.

Via [Wolters World](#), [Epic Family Escapes](#), [Travel The Top](#), [Tours by Foot - Chicago](#), [trovexgo](#)

Free to walk · WonderFest \$27 online (2026)

10

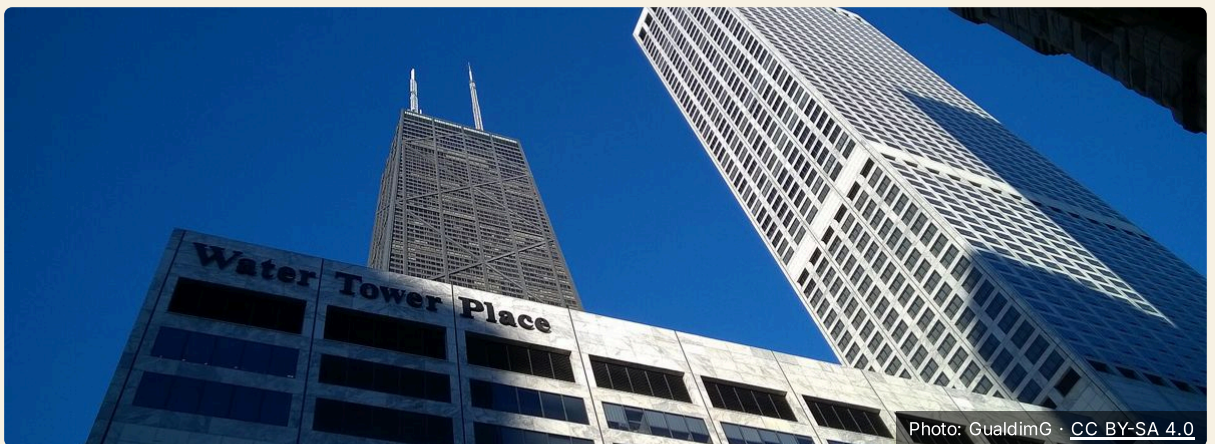


Photo: GualdimG · CC BY-SA 4.0

The Magnificent Mile

NEAR NORTH SIDE · GREAT FOR KIDS

A mile of Michigan Avenue from the river to Oak Street: the Wrigley Building and Tribune Tower, the 1869 Water Tower that survived the Great Fire, the huge Starbucks Reserve Roastery and, at Christmas, every tree wrapped in lights. Busy - mind your bag.

Via [Ashlynn Eaton](#), [Architectural Digest](#), [Samuel Ciochon - Your Chicago Lifestyle](#), [LukeGee Travels](#), [Backttalk](#)

Free

DETAILS

11



Chicago Cultural Center

THE LOOP • GREAT FOR KIDS

The world's largest Tiffany glass dome, free to see, opposite Millennium Park - and clean public toilets on several floors.

Via [CURIO](#)

Free

DETAILS

12



Maggie Daley Park

THE LOOP • GREAT FOR KIDS

A huge play garden for ages 2-12 by Millennium Park, and in winter a skating ribbon that winds through the trees with skyline views - much less crowded than the Millennium Park rink.

Via [Epic Family Escapes](#), [CURIO](#), [A Dempsey Story](#), [Travel The Top](#), [Chad and Claire](#)

Free to visit · skating ticketed

DETAILS

If you only have one day

ONE

1

The classic loop

- | | |
|-------|--|
| 08:30 | Breakfast and the Bean. Pancakes at Wildberry, then Cloud Gate before the crowds. |
| 10:00 | Art Institute (not Tuesdays). Two hours with the Impressionists and the festive Thorne rooms. |
| 12:00 | Christkindlmarket at Daley Plaza. Arrive near opening on a weekday: bratwurst, pretzels and a mug of hot chocolate. |
| 14:00 | Skydeck or Macy's. Up the Willis Tower on a clear day, or the Macy's windows and Walnut Room tree. |
| 16:00 | Skating as the lights come on. Maggie Daley ribbon or the free Millennium Park rink - book a slot. |
| 18:00 | Deep dish and the Mile. Lou Malnati's (allow 45 minutes), then the lights on Michigan Avenue. |

Three days, grouped by area

DAY

1

The Loop at Christmas

- | | |
|-----|---|
| AM | The Bean and the Art Institute. |
| PM | Christkindlmarket and Macy's on State Street. |
| EVE | Skating and the city tree, then deep dish in River North. |

DAY

2

Museums

- | | |
|-----|---|
| AM | Field Museum and Shedd Aquarium on the Museum Campus. |
| PM | Or the Museum of Science and Industry for Christmas Around the World. |
| EVE | Lights on the Magnificent Mile, dinner in Chinatown. |
-

DAY

3

Neighbourhoods

- | | |
|-----|--|
| AM | Skydeck on a clear morning. |
| PM | Lincoln Park Zoo and Conservatory (free). |
| EVE | ZooLights after dark, or the Wrigleyville Christkindlmarket. |
-

DEEP DISH, ITALIAN BEEF AND A CHICAGO DOG

Where to eat

Chicago eats big: deep-dish pizza (allow 45 minutes), thin tavern-style squares that locals actually eat, dripping Italian beef and the hot dog 'dragged through the garden' - never with ketchup. Every place is credited to the creator who recommended it, and prices carry the year.

Lou Malnati's

RIVER NORTH (WELLS & HUBBARD) AND ELSEWHERE • DEEP DISH

\$\$

The deep dish locals most often recommend, with booth seating and quick service for families; about \$20-30 a person (2025).

Family friendly

Via [Tours by Foot - Chicago](#), [Crosby Grace Travels](#), [Travel Tips Group](#), [Travel The Top](#), [Daily Drop Pro](#), [JackxJo](#)

VISIT

Pequod's Pizza

LINCOLN PARK • DEEP DISH

\$\$

A dark, caramelised cheese crust that several creators rate the best in the city. It takes 45-60 minutes and is a 17-minute walk from the train.

Family friendly

Via [Johnny Trekkie](#), [Jeremy Jacobowitz](#), [Brian Lindo](#), [Attaché](#), [Arielle Yasmine](#)

VISIT

Giordano's

SEVERAL DOWNTOWN • DEEP DISH

\$\$

Stuffed deep dish since 1974; a 10-inch feeds two. Dinner waits can be 1-2 hours, but the lunch special of a ready-made pizza arrives in 10-15 minutes (\$13 combo, 2024).

Family friendly

Via [Camden David](#), [adulthood with angela](#), [Johnny Trekkie](#), [Chad and Claire](#)

VISIT

Pat's Pizza

LINCOLN PARK • TAVERN-STYLE PIZZA

\$\$

The thin, crisp, square-cut pizza Luis Gusto says most Chicagoans actually eat. Order the Pat special.

Family friendly

Via [Luis Gusto](#), [Adam and Madalyn](#)

VISIT

Portillo's

RIVER NORTH AND THE LOOP • HOT DOGS & ITALIAN BEEF

\$

The classic: a Chicago dog, an Italian beef dipped with peppers and a chocolate cake shake. Two dogs, two fries and a shake were \$19 in 2024. Check the kiosk total before you pay.

Family friendly

Via [Daily Drop Pro](#), [adulting with angela](#), [Chad and Claire](#), [Camden David](#), [Nicole Laeno](#), [Rithmic ASMR](#)

VISIT

Mr. Beef

RIVER NORTH • ITALIAN BEEF

\$

The Italian beef stand made famous by The Bear; order it dipped. Still cash only (2025), with a queue out of the door - two sandwiches were \$26 in 2024.

Grown-ups

Via [United](#), [The Hive Drive](#), [Daily Drop Pro](#), [Ashlynn Eaton](#)

VISIT

Garrett Popcorn

MICHIGAN AVENUE AND THE LOOP • POPCORN

\$

Since 1949. The Chicago Mix is caramel and cheese together; a small bag is about \$5 (2025), with free samples and a seasonal hot cocoa caramel crisp.

Family friendly

Via [Roseland Lashay](#), [Means To Travel](#), [Joe Parys Eats](#) 📺, [CBS Chicago](#)

VISIT

Wildberry Pancakes and Cafe

RANDOLPH STREET, OPPOSITE MILLENNIUM PARK • BREAKFAST

\$\$

Fluffy pancakes in many flavours with window seats over the park; about \$16 for pancakes and coffee (2025). Expect a wait at weekends.

Family friendly

Via [Roaming Routes](#), [Lia Lavon](#), [trovexgo](#), [Travel Tips Group](#)

VISIT

The Berghoff

THE LOOP • GERMAN-AMERICAN

\$\$

Open since 1898, decorated for the holidays, with hearty German food and its own root beer - a warm stop near the Christkindlmarket.

Family friendly

Via [Chad and Claire](#), [CBS Chicago](#)

VISIT

Lou Mitchell's

WEST LOOP, NEAR UNION STATION • DINER BREAKFAST

\$\$

A classic diner breakfast near Union Station; a large breakfast for a group was about \$50 (2024).

Family friendly

Via [Daily Drop Pro](#)

VISIT

Manny's Cafeteria and Deli

SOUTH LOOP • JEWISH DELI

\$

A cafeteria-style deli since 1942: huge pastrami on rye at reasonable prices, and cherry pie.

Family friendly

Via [Attaché](#), [Johnny Trekkie](#)

VISIT

Chiu Quon Bakery

CHINATOWN • CHINESE BAKERY

\$

Since 1986: BBQ pork buns and egg tarts for breakfast. Chinatown is cheap, open late and reached by the Red Line or the water taxi.

Family friendly

Via [Luis Gusto](#)

VISIT

For a grown-ups' night: a Glühwein at the Christkindlmarket, then Cindy's rooftop above the Millennium Park rink, London House's rooftop by the river (igloos in winter), or the tiki cocktails at Three Dots and a Dash in River North. Wrigleyville's themed Christmas pop-up bars are cheesy fun but busy and pricey, and not for children - book ahead. Second City in Old Town has nightly improv. You must be 21 to drink, and bars ask for photo ID - take your passport or photocard licence. Opening times and menus change, so check before you travel. Wiley Fox is not paid for restaurant listings.

BEFORE YOU GO

Getting around Chicago

From the airports

From O'Hare, the Blue Line runs 24 hours and takes 40-45 minutes to downtown; boarding at O'Hare costs \$5 (free with a pass). From Midway, the Orange Line takes 20-25 minutes for \$2.50. A taxi from O'Hare averages about \$50, and the city's shared-ride flat fare is \$30 a person (Chicago airports, Oct 2026).

Via [Roaming Routes](#), [Chicago Like A Local](#), [Camden David](#), [Everything Chicagoland](#)

Tickets: just tap

A train ride is \$2.50 and a bus \$2.25, with two free transfers within two hours. Tap a contactless card or phone at the gate - no ticket needed. Passes are \$5 for a day, \$15 for three days and \$20 for seven days in the Ventra app or at airport machines; the 7-day pass covers the O'Hare charge.

Via [Chicago Like A Local](#), [Camden David](#), [CityNerd](#), [Traveling Taya](#)

Getting round the sights

Every L line except the Yellow runs through the Loop; Clark/Lake connects to all of them. For ZooLights take the Brown Line to Sedgwick or bus 151. The Red Line goes to Wrigley Field, and the Metra Electric from Millennium Station to Hyde Park for the Museum of Science and Industry. In cold weather, the Pedway tunnels link some downtown buildings and stations.

Via [Luis Gusto](#), [CityNerd](#), [LukeGee Travels](#), [Ashlynnne Eaton](#), [Everything Chicagoland](#), [Tours by Foot - Chicago](#)

Night travel

The Red and Blue Lines run 24 hours; other lines run roughly 4am to 1am. Locals prefer the bus late at night because the driver can see you, and say to pad journey times outside rush hour. Rideshares can be near impossible at rush hour - Caira Button gave up at ZooLights and took the bus.

Via [Caira Button](#), [Chicago Like A Local](#), [Tours by Foot - Chicago](#), [Chism Prism](#)

Water taxi and bikes

The Chicago Water Taxi to Chinatown (\$6-10, 2025-26) is a cheap way onto the river, but check winter service. Divvy bikes are \$1 to unlock plus 20 cents a minute, or \$19.90 for a day (Divvy, Oct 2026) - not much fun in a Chicago December.

What it costs

CTA single train ride	\$2.50 (bus \$2.25); fare chart dated 20 Feb 2023, still current
2026-10-05	

CTA 1-day pass	\$5
2026-10-05	

CTA 3-day pass	\$15
2026-10-05	

CTA 7-day pass	\$20
2026-10-05	

Blue Line fare from O'Hare	\$5 adult (unlimited pass boards free)
2026-10-05	

Taxi O'Hare to downtown	About \$50 average; shared-ride flat fare \$30 per person; \$4 airport departure tax
2026-10-05	

Divvy classic bike	\$1 unlock + \$0.20/min; Day Pass \$19.90
2026-10-05	

Skydeck Chicago	From \$32 adult, from \$24 child 3-11, under 3 free
2026-10-05	

360 Chicago	From \$30 adult, from \$20 child 3-11 (gate price from \$35)
2026-10-05	

Art Institute of Chicago	\$32 adult, children free
2026-10-05	

Field Museum	\$30 adult guest (child price not yet confirmed); free Wednesdays for Illinois residents
2026-10-05	

Museum of Science and Industry	\$25.95 adult, \$14.95 child 3-11 (general admission)
2026-10-05	

ZooLights 2026	\$7-\$12 fixed date in advance; \$20 on the day or flexible; free Mondays 23 Nov-14 Dec with booking
2026-10-05	

McCormick Tribune Ice Rink

Admission free; skate hire not yet confirmed

2026-10-05

Maggie Daley Skating
Ribbon skate hire

\$17 online / \$19 walk-up Mon-Thu; \$21 / \$23 Fri-Sun and holidays;
own skates free first session, \$5 after

2026-10-05

Christkindlmarket mug
(2025 price)

\$10 empty; stein \$20 (latest year only, 2025). 2026 price and
Gluhwein price not yet confirmed

2026-10-05

Navy Pier Winter WonderFest

\$27 online 24h ahead, \$32 door; under 3s free; skating included

2026-10-05

Navy Pier Centennial
Wheel

\$10 add-on with WonderFest ticket (same day); standalone price not
yet confirmed

2026-10-05

Architecture river cruise (First
Lady)

From \$57, but runs March-November only, so not in
December

2026-10-05

Chicago CityPASS

\$144 adult, \$114 child, valid 9 days

2026-10-05

Chicago sales tax (general goods)

10.25%; restaurants also pay 0.5% restaurant tax

2026-10-05

Creator prices carry the video date. Anything older than 18 months is marked to check.

Quick tips

Book the timed things

Skating slots, the Walnut Room, Skydeck and ZooLights all sell out at Christmas. One creator could only get an 8am skating slot over the 2025 holiday weekend.

Dress for the wind

Lake wind makes 25°F feel like 10°F. Layers, a hat, gloves, warm boots and hand warmers (from any Walgreens).

Carry some cash

Cards and phone pay work almost everywhere, but creators found most Christkindlmarket food stalls cash only - there are ATMs on site, with queues.

Tax and tip on top

Prices never include the 10.25% sales tax. Tip 18-20% in restaurants, but check for a service charge first.

Weekday mornings win

The Christkindlmarket, the Bean and the Walnut Room are calm on weekday mornings and packed on Saturday afternoons.

Christmas Day

The Christkindlmarket ends at 4pm on 24 December. On 25 December many museums, ZooLights and Navy Pier's WonderFest are closed - but the Skydeck is open every day and the Maggie Daley ribbon has morning sessions.

WF

Spotted a "donation" scam, a closed rink or a street that felt wrong? Drop a community report on the map - it helps the next family.

THE SMALL THINGS VISITORS WORRY ABOUT

Local tips for Chicago

Every tip here was checked against an official or trusted source (CTA, the City of Chicago, Chicago Police, the venues, CBP and others) on the date shown. Rules and prices change, so tap the link to double-check before you travel.

Paying for transport

How much is a CTA ride?

A train ride costs \$2.50 and a bus ride \$2.25. Two extra rides within two hours are free. The fare chart on CTA's site is dated 20 Feb 2023 and is still the one shown today. [Checked 2026-10 ↗](#)

Can I just tap my bank card?

Yes. You can pay with a contactless bank card, a phone wallet, a Ventra card or a Ventra ticket. Tap-to-pay covers full and reduced fares only, not passes. The Ventra app shows balances, passes and train times. [Checked 2026-10 ↗](#)

Is a pass worth it?

CTA/Pace passes cost \$5 for 1 day, \$15 for 3 days and \$20 for 7 days. They run from first use (1 day = 24 hours). A 3-day Ventra ticket can be bought at the Ventra machines at O'Hare and Midway.

[Checked 2026-10 ↗](#)

What is the O'Hare \$5 rule?

Boarding a train at O'Hare costs \$5 (adult) instead of \$2.50. If you hold an unlimited pass, boarding at O'Hare costs no extra. Going into O'Hare from the city costs the normal fare. [Checked 2026-10 ↗](#)

What do reduced fares and children pay?

CTA lists reduced (\$1.25 train) and student (\$0.75) fares. Reduced fares need a permit issued by NITA. Whether UK visitors or young children qualify for free or reduced fares: Not yet confirmed, so check CTA before travel. [Checked 2026-10 ↗](#)

How long is the Blue Line from O'Hare?

CTA says the Blue Line takes 40-45 minutes from O'Hare to downtown. It runs 24 hours a day, seven days a week, and every train from O'Hare goes through downtown.

[Checked 2026-10 ↗](#)

How long is the Orange Line from Midway?

CTA says 20-25 minutes from Midway to downtown. The Orange Line is not 24-hour: Midway to Loop trains run about 3:30am-1:05am on weekdays. The N62 Archer bus covers overnight. [Checked 2026-10 ↗](#)

Is Metra worth knowing about?

Metra runs commuter trains to the suburbs. Metra's fare page lists a \$7 Saturday or Sunday day pass and a Weekend Pass (page does not print a year). The Ventra app also sells a Regional Day Pass for CTA, Metra and Pace. [Checked 2026-10 ↗](#)

How much are Divvy bikes?

Divvy single rides cost \$1 to unlock plus \$0.20 a minute for classic bikes. E-bikes are about \$0.44 a minute. A Day Pass is \$19.90 for unlimited classic rides in 24 hours. Winter availability and snow limits: Not yet confirmed. [Checked 2026-10 ↗](#)

What does a taxi from the airport cost?

O'Hare to downtown averages about \$50 by taxi, depending on traffic (Chicago airports site). The city's shared-ride taxi flat fares are \$30 a person from O'Hare to downtown and \$18 a person from Midway to downtown. A \$4 airport departure tax is added to taxi rides from airports.

[Checked 2026-10 ↗](#)

What do rideshares cost from the airport?

A typical Uber or Lyft fare from O'Hare to the Loop: Not yet confirmed (prices are dynamic and no official figure found). The city charges a ground transportation tax on app rides, including airport trips.

[Checked 2026-10 ↗](#)

Water & snacks

Is the tap water safe?

Yes. The City of Chicago says its tap water meets or exceeds all US EPA standards. Bring a refillable bottle. [Checked 2026-10 ↗](#)

CHRISTMAS ***Can we bring snacks to the lights?***

Not to ZooLights: outside food and drink is not allowed. Lightscape has hot and cold

drinks, snacks and kids' food on the trail. ZooLights sells hot chocolate, churros and s'mores. [Checked 2026-10 ↗](#)

Toilets

Where are free toilets downtown?

The Chicago Cultural Center has restrooms on floors 1, 2 and 4 on the north side, with water fountains nearby. Millennium Park is open 6am-11pm, but its East and West restrooms near the Pritzker Pavilion were noted as closing for construction from 18 Sep (year not shown), so check first. [Checked 2026-10 ↗](#)

Parks & play

CHRISTMAS *Do kids need tickets and can I bring a pushchair?*

Every child at ZooLights needs a ticket, including infants, and strollers are allowed but crowds can make them hard to use. Lightscape allows strollers except on 21+ nights. Navy Pier WonderFest is free for under 3s. [Checked 2026-10 ↗](#)

CHRISTMAS *Do I need to book ice skating?*

Yes at Maggie Daley: everyone needs a ticket for a set two-hour session. Skate hire is \$17-\$19 Mon-Thu and \$21-\$23 Fri-Sun and holidays. Ribbon season is 13 Nov - 7 Mar. Millennium Park rink reservation rules: Not yet confirmed. [Checked 2026-10 ↗](#)

Money & tipping

What sales tax will I pay?

General goods in the City of Chicago carry 10.25% sales tax (state revenue guide, edition dated before 1 Jan 2026, so confirm the rate finder). Restaurants also pay a 0.5% Chicago restaurant tax. The exact total on a meal: Not yet confirmed.

[Checked 2026-10 ↗](#)

How much should I tip?

Tipped staff in Chicago have a lower base wage (\$12.96 an hour from 1 July 2026, against \$17.05 standard), so tips matter. The usual 18-20% restaurant tip is common practice, but not yet confirmed on an official page. [Checked 2026-10 ↗](#)

Are the free museum days for me?

No. Free days are for Illinois residents. Field Museum's free Wednesdays are for Illinois residents. MSI's Illinois Free Days need a zip code check. Art Institute's Third Thursdays and summer Thursdays are for Illinois residents. Shedd's \$19.95 rate is for Chicago residents. [Checked 2026-10 ↗](#)

Is the CityPASS worth it?

Chicago CityPASS is \$144 adult and \$114 child, valid 9 days, and covers a choice of attractions (Shedd, Skydeck, Field, 360 Chicago, MSI, Art Institute, Adler, Shoreline Sightseeing). The Shoreline boat tour may not run in winter: Not yet confirmed.

[Checked 2026-10 ↗](#)

CHRISTMAS *Will the market take cards?*

Whether Christkindlmarket vendors take cards or cash only in 2026: Not yet confirmed. The 2025 mug cost \$10 empty. Carry a little cash and a card.

[Checked 2026-10 ↗](#)

Phones & data

What about UK phone roaming?

Charges depend on your network and when you joined. EE's Travel Data Pass starts from GBP 2.72 a day. Vodafone says GBP 2.75 a day for plans from Aug 2021. Three charges GBP 8 a day for new joiners from 1 April 2026. Whether each covers the USA, and eSIM prices: Not yet confirmed.

[Checked 2026-10 ↗](#)

How much is ESTA?

The official ESTA fee is \$40.27. Apply only on the official CBP site, esta.cbp.dhs.gov, as other sites charge more. Validity, 90-day stay and how early to apply: Not yet confirmed on the page fetched, so confirm on the site. [Checked 2026-10 ↗](#)

Safety habits

Who do I call in an emergency?

Call 911 for emergencies. For police non-emergencies call 311, which is open 24

What are the cannabis rules?

Cannabis is legal for adults 21 and over, but public consumption is illegal. It must not be

hours a day, seven days a week.

Checked 2026-10 ↗

used in a vehicle and must not be taken across state lines. Airport screening rules: Not yet confirmed here, so treat airports as no-go. Checked 2026-10 ↗

Do I need ID for alcohol?

Adults-only holiday events state 21+ with photo ID required (Shedd's Holiday House Party). The general Illinois drinking age of 21 is not yet confirmed on an official page here. Carry your passport or a photocard ID.

Checked 2026-10 ↗

How cold does it get?

Wind off Lake Michigan makes it feel colder than the thermometer. Not yet confirmed: no official wind chill figures were gathered. Check the National Weather Service Chicago forecast for hazards and dress in layers with hats and gloves.

Checked 2026-10 ↗

CHRISTMAS ***How early does it get dark?***

Sunset in Chicago is 4:20pm on 1 and 15 Dec, 4:22pm on 21 Dec, 4:24pm on 24 and 25 Dec and 4:29pm on 31 Dec 2026. Sunrise is about 7:16am on 24 Dec. Plan outdoor sights for the morning.

Checked 2026-10 ↗

Is the lakefront ice safe?

Not yet confirmed on an official page. Treat any ice on Lake Michigan or the harbours as unsafe, and keep children back from the water's edge in winter. The NWS Chicago site carries local hazards. Checked 2026-10 ↗

Local ways

Can I get a free local guide?

Yes. Chicago Greeter visits and InstaGreeter walks are completely free and led by volunteers. Winter and Christmas availability: Not yet confirmed, so book ahead. Checked 2026-10 ↗

How do I stay out of the cold downtown?

The Pedway is a network of walkways linking downtown buildings. Opening hours vary by passage. An old city map says normal hours are 7am-5pm Mon-Fri (2013 map, latest year only), so do not rely on it for evenings or weekends. Checked 2026-10 ↗

What if I lose something on CTA?

Where is a 24-hour pharmacy?

Contact the bus garage or rail terminal for the line. CTA suggests waiting and calling the next day. The main line 1-888-YOUR-CTA is staffed weekdays 7am-5:30pm.

Checked 2026-10 ↗

Walgreens at 757 N Michigan Ave is listed as open 24 hours, but the pharmacy counter has set hours (Mon-Fri 9am-8pm with meal breaks), so you may not get prescriptions at night. Check before you go.

Checked 2026-10 ↗

Travel with Wiley Fox

Official travel advice for 200+ countries, community reports, one-tap SOS, and QR wristbands so lost children and lost bags find their way back.

Our sources

This guide summarises these creators' videos in our own words. Watch the originals - they are worth it. Crime data: Chicago Police Department, Crimes data (City of Chicago Data Portal) (Jun 2026 to Aug 2026). Crimes recorded by Chicago Police from June to August 2026, counted within about one mile of each area centre, plus the Police 2025 year-end review and Data Portal trends to 27 September 2026. These are reports, not convictions; they include indoor and domestic incidents, and are not adjusted for the visitors and commuters who pass through busy areas.

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